

**Medford School Committee Budget Meeting**  
**May 25, 2022**  
**7:15PM**

**Via zoom**

Jenny Graham (acting as Chair): Roll: Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau: Present  
Mea Mustone joined at 7:50PM  
Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn Absent

Dave Murphy: This is the 4th budget meeting. **Insert link to slides.**

Paul Ruseau: I move that we submit a request for A, B, and D to the municipal government in the sum of \$72.4 million dollars. Further, in the event that the State of Massachusetts does not fund school meals as they are presently considering, the district will proceed with free meals nonetheless and make a request to the municipal government for supplemental funding to cover the costs of continuing our free meal policy.

Dave Murphy: That actual number could be lower. The way I interpret your motion is we build a budget based on all the priorities. If it turns out to be \$71.8 vs. \$72.4, it would still have the same legal effect.

Paul Ruseau: It depends on the number. If it comes down to moving things into esser funds, I am not ok with that.

Dave Murphy: We would come back to you in June to express our Esser funding priorities. I want to explain how we come to finding savings at some point.

Melanie McLaughlin: I want to clarify member Ruseau's motion, with the 72.4, that is because you are not including C because ESSER would cover that. (ABD). I would ask that we go back to the strong consideration page, Category E,

Dave Murphy: DEI and Registrar: are goals we could pursue. Right now with not knowing what we can pursue on the school and city side, there is less priority to hire these roles. Largely different applicant pool and the cycle is off. We can pursue it at a different time. Metal Fab landed in category D and Media Tech in E. With neither having enrollment stating necessity right now. Re Nurse Registration piece: idea is a position that we could expeditiously move/register kids into school faster by having medical personnel helping. It is a need but not a vital position. We are exploring ways to have that role done without funding another position. Library: we have gone back and forth on but we need to develop the curriculum first before making the personnel investment.

Kathy Kreatz; Highest priority A. B recommended with ESSER. I need clarification on Category B? Is that recommended ESSER. Why is C based on ESSER?

Dave Murphy: Category B is three personnel related priorities: newcomer teachers, adj. Counselors and district wide nurse. Given they are personnel priorities, it would be a preference to have an operating budget to absorb these. But we know there will be limitations on our budget capacity. We need to do these things anyway based on the impact of the pandemic on our students. In this case, the urgency and need and connection to pandemic, we would use ESSER funding for this. In C, we don't want to use the operating budget and they fit neatly within ESSER funding guidelines. With B, we would prefer using op. Budget. It is not an inappropriate usage of ESSER funds. I don't have a crystal ball, there is a prospect that the urgency of these funding priorities will dissipate the further we get away from the pandemic. It is about the urgency and the connection to the pandemic.

Kathy Kreatz; Last week I reached out to Donato and he told me that the House did approve \$110 m for free lunch and it went over to the Senate. I agree with the language in Paul's motion that we would give additional funding if it doesn't pass.

Dave Murphy: MASS has made this a priority for funding to the Senate.

Mea Mustone: I second PR's motion for A, B and D.

Jenny Graham: Motion on floor, request for A, B and D for \$72.4 million (and then meal portion if not funded by state). Are there other questions from the committee on the motion and the deck?

Paul Ruseau; ROLL: Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, YES; Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn : Absent Motion passes

Melanie McLaughlin: Congratulations on the process and thanks to Mr. Murphy for pulling all this together. Thank you for all the hard work.

Dave Murphy: I appreciate the committee's patience, forbearance and willingness to work through this the last few weeks. Although different, I believe we covered it with more efficiency and transparency. We are not doing our job if we don't look to identify any flexibility and efficiencies in our current budget. One will be about identifying positions: looking at enrollment trends, there may be strands we can collapse. There are some one time related expenses that I hope don't continue to carry over. We may roll over from the current spending freeze we are under right now. We will keep the committee apprised of any savings.

Melanie McLaughlin: I ask that the deck be shared on our website as well as the full budget proposal. As soon as they are ready, I ask that they be published.

Dave Murphy: The deck will be published tonight

Jenny Graham: This is our request to the Municipal government as the mayor makes her proposal to the city council. We will await approval from the city council come July 1. Based on that allocation, we will have another meeting to adopt the budget.

Dave Murphy: We need a public budget hearing first.

Melanie McLaughlin: What is the process if the appropriation is less than what the SC has asked for?

Dave Murphy: We need to prepare for that contingency. We have a responsibility to implement the budget to serve the students well. If they don't we will come back to try to bridge that delta. The month of June will be heavily weighted by the budget.

Paul Ruseau: I greatly appreciate Mr. Murphy's efforts but I need to point out the only time we hear about competing priorities is from Mr. Murphy and not the Mayor's office or City Council. Nobody else says that out loud. Our responsibility as SC is the children and their education not on the competing municipal priorities. We need to figure out what we need and then ask for it. We spend time worrying about the municipal government's finances. The Municipal government can raise taxes if they see fit.

Dave Murphy: I say this as a former SC chair. We don't disagree on this. You are correct it is your responsibility to advocate for the students. It is the school administration to do that and plan for any possible contingency. We will make it work wherever it lands. Might not be as well. The audience I am speaking to is not the municipal government. Those members of the community who watch these meetings need to know we take our financial responsibility seriously. We ask for what we need and make it work. I know there are people who want to know about transparency and coherence. It is important that we show this responsibility.

Mea Mustone: Motion to adjourn the meeting

Melanie McLaughlin: Seconded the motion.

Roll: Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau 6/0 one absent. Meeting adjourned at 8:31PM.